Dr. Sophie Rose Lewis

Personal Information

Nationality
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Education

Doctor of Philosophy in Political Ecology The University of British Columbia, Vancouver, Canada	2015 - 2021
Master of Science in Conservation and Forest Protection Imperial College London, United Kingdom	2008 - 2009
Bachelor of Science in Ecology and Environmental Biology The University of Leeds, United Kingdom	2005 - 2008

Key Skills and Competencies

- Forest governance and policy specialist with over twelve years' experience in forest landscape governance and environmental politics in Southeast Asia, with a focus on customary tenure security, resource rights and access, research-to-policy pathways, and policy advocacy.
- Demonstrated experience in designing, managing, and quality-assuring applied research projects with methodological rigor, ethical standards, and policy relevance; developed evidence-based case studies for policy, supported by a robust publication record (ORCID iD).
- Experience working international programmes including the UK's Reversing Environmental Degradation in Africa and Asia (REDAA) programme, the EU's Forest Law Enforcement, Governance and Trade (EU-FLEGT) initiative in Thailand, and the UN-REDD+ programme in Cambodia.
- Experience leading and collaborating on multi-country governance and rights consultancies with governments, private sector, civil society, NGOs, research bodies, multilateral agencies, and Indigenous Peoples and local communities
- Skilled in coordination, partner management, and grant development, with a record in designing and working on multi-stakeholder projects involving log frame development, monitoring, evaluation and learning, and donor accountability.
- Experienced in developing and facilitating trainings and workshops for diverse audiences, including policymakers, NGOs, civil society, and academic stakeholders.
- Trained in Qualitative Research Methods in Interdisciplinary Contexts and proficient in qualitative data analysis (NVivo) and reference management (Mendeley).

Career History

Independent Consultant January 2026 - Ongoing
Forest Governance Lab Consultancy,– Bangkok, Thailand

- ADRA UK · Timor-Leste · February 2026- **Strategic Planning & Technical Writing**
    - Development and coordination of project concept note with log frame for an EU call to support Timor-Leste's Directorate General of Forestry in strengthening institutional capacity for priority forestry projects.

Senior Policy Outreach and Gender Inclusion Coordinator - Explore Program April 2024 - October 2025
RECOFTC, The Centre for People and Forests – Bangkok, Thailand

- Provided strategic and technical leadership for RECOFTC's Explore Program on research-to-policy, supporting science–policy engagement, governance reform, and participatory-action-research of forest landscape governance research across seven Southeast Asian countries.
- Designed and implemented policy outreach strategies that translated applied research into actionable policy influence, including stakeholder mapping, advocacy planning, and evidence communication frameworks.
- Coordinated and strengthened National Advisory Committees (NACs) in seven countries (Thailand, Lao PDR, Viet Nam, Cambodia, Indonesia, Philippines, and Timor-Leste), aligning research agendas with national forest and land policy processes.
- Managed regional capacity-development programs on Participatory Action Research (PAR) for Policy Outreach, combining classroom training and field-based mentoring to support policy influence and stakeholder engagement.
- Led Explore's gender inclusion strategy, ensuring equity and representation across research teams, advisory bodies, and capacity-development initiatives.
- Oversaw the Women's Doctoral Scholarship Program, facilitating financial support and mentorship for female PhD researchers.
- Provided technical input to Explore's grants, evaluations, and donor reporting, ensuring coherence with Sida-funded monitoring and reporting.

Postdoctoral Researcher July 2022 - March 2024
Faculty of Political Science Chulalongkorn University – Bangkok, Thailand

- Conducted qualitative field research interviewing government offices, civil society, local communities, and Indigenous Peoples in Thailand to examine the socio-political and institutional dimensions of forest governance, focusing on

how inequality in land rights and resource use and access are produced and reproduced in both urban and rural contexts.

- Ensured methodological rigor, ethical compliance, and adherence to Free, Prior and Informed Consent (FPIC) principles
- Applied a political ecology framing to produce nuanced critiques of Thailand's Bio-Circular-Green Economic Model and Eco-Industrial City Policies and associated grassroots land and resource access challenges.

Independent Consultant September 2022 - January 2023

RECOFTC (Southeast Asia) & IIED (United Kingdom) - Reversing Environmental Degradation in Africa and Asia (REDAA) – Work located in Bangkok, Thailand.

- Coordinated and conducted a scoping study to identify twelve research-to-action priorities for environmental restoration and sustainable natural resource management in Southeast Asia. The study combined a review of peer-reviewed and grey literature with key informant interviews, a regional workshop, and field research in Nan (Thailand) and Tonle Sap (Cambodia) with Thai and Cambodian research teams.
- Coordinated with RECOFTC offices in Bangkok, Cambodia, and Indonesia, and with IIED to deliver outputs on schedule, culminating in a published report for the REDAA programme - https://www.redaa.org/scoping-study-research-action-priorities-redaa-programme-southeast-asia

Independent Consultant June 2022 - February 2023

Landesa - United States of America (work located in Thailand)

- Conducted desk research to developing a narrative land and natural resource rights profile for Thailand, focusing on Trang province and its palm oil supply chain.
- The work drew on scientific and grey literature as well as open-source data, including information from Thai government websites and other Thailand-based sources.
- The profile provided a detailed summary of trends, key issues, and recommended actions related to land and resource rights—including for women and Indigenous Peoples—alongside analysis of legislative instruments, socio-economic data, maps, and regional statistics on land use, certification, and conflicts. I
- From the profile in collaboration with Landesa we developed a regional risk score for Trang's palm oil sector using the organization's indicators and scoring methodology.

Independent Consultant May 2022 - August 2022

RECOFTC- Mekong Region Land Governance project - Bangkok, Thailand

- Compiled, verified, and expanded co-authors' data and analysis to develop a peer-reviewed journal article evaluating legal frameworks for implementing customary forest tenure across five countries in the Lower Mekong subregion https://doi.org/10.1080/1747423X.2023.2184513

Independent Consultant 2020

RECOFTC Thailand Country Program - UK & Thailand

- Led an FAO-funded study on civil society's role in the EU Voluntary Partnership Agreement (VPA) timber verification process, conducting literature reviews and structured interviews across five case study countries (Cameroon, Ghana, Indonesia, Republic of Congo, and Vietnam).
- Coordinated a Bangkok-based team remotely from the UK to collect and analyse survey data on Thailand's civil society engagement, producing two in-depth reports to guide future VPA implementation support.

Ph.D. Researcher 2015-2021

The University of British Columbia - Canada & Thailand

- Successfully designed and executed a three-year research project examining the human rights dimensions and links between illegal logging, land rights, and government policies in Thailand (https://dx.doi.org/10.14288/1.0406142 & https://doi.org/10.2458/jpe.2398), securing two fieldwork grants (CAD 6,500 and CAD 4,500) to conduct qualitative field research in Thailand
- Conducted qualitative research including extensive in-depth interviews with local Karen Pwo Indigenous Peoples, civil society, and government officers, alongside household surveys to examine local timber rights, access, and land tenure.
- Conducted further research with national stakeholders from the Thai government, the Food and Agriculture Organization, Thai civil society organizations, the private sector, and the European Forest Institute regarding participation in processes to reform and legalise timber supply chains (EU-FLEGT)
- Ensured methodological rigor, ethical compliance, and adherence to Free, Prior and Informed Consent (FPIC) principles throughout, while managing and collaborating with a translator and research assistant.

Program Associate

RECOFTC Cambodia Country Program - Cambodia & Thailand

2011-2014

- Worked on projects supporting communities to strengthen tenure and resource rights, providing technical support across the full project cycle including proposal development, monitoring and evaluation, budgeting, and reporting.
- Designed and facilitated training of trainers on climate change, adaptation, and agroforestry for Cambodian civil society organizations and government officers.
- Managed WWF-funded community reforestation grants across three provinces, supporting five local communities in proposal writing, project implementation, and financial reporting.
- Led development of a USD 135,000 proposal on Strengthening the Role of Community Forestry in Forest Law Enforcement, Governance and Trade,
- Represented RECOFTC in conferences and events, and contributed to academic publications on forest governance in the Greater Mekong Subregion (https://www.mdpi.com/1999-4907/10/1/47 ; https://www.mdpi.com/1999-4907/6/10/3433/htm)

Program Assistant

The Organic Research Centre - UK 2011

- Developed the foundations for a UK Eco-Agroforestry Network by building partnerships with local farmers, NGOs, and UK government agencies and organising and facilitating two policy and network workshops, including field visits to farms and participatory activities to develop a common UK Eco-Agroforestry policy agenda.
- Researched the potential for UK Eco-Agroforestry - Lewis, S.R. (2011). Agroforestry Survey: A Summary of Response. Organic e-prints, http://orgprints.org/19174/

Traineeship

European Forest Institute, Forest Ecology and Management -Joensuu, Finland 2009

- Contributed to EU-level research on climate change adaptation for Protected Forest Areas, analysing policy gaps and forest management responses across Europe. Supported the drafting of the working paper *"Role of Forest Policy in Fighting Climate Change – Forest Policy Work Group Report"* for the EFI Forest Policy Work Group, synthesizing findings on forest governance and adaptation strategies.